

Capsicum annuum & *C. frutescens* (Solanaceae)

Cayenne, Cayenne Pepper, Chili

Originally from the tropical regions of the Americas, cayenne was first introduced to Europe in the 16th century. In cooking, it is renowned for its hot, burning taste, and it is not surprising to learn that, medicinally, it is a powerful warming stimulant. It acts on the circulation and digestion and is used to treat a wide range of complaints from arthritis and chilblains to colic and diarrhea.



Cayenne is so popular in Mexico where it originates that it is even used to flavor ice cream.

Habitat & Cultivation

Cayenne is native to the tropical Americas, and is now cultivated throughout the tropics, especially in Africa and India. It is grown from seed in early spring and flourishes in hot, moist conditions. The fruit is harvested when ripe in summer and is dried in the shade.

Related Species

Many closely related species and varieties of *C. frutescens* exist, all with different grades of pungency. Paprika, or Hungarian pepper (one of the mildest peppers), and the large green and red peppers that are eaten as vegetables are both varieties of *C. annuum* and are important medicinal foods.

Key Constituents

- Capsaicin (0.1–1.5%)
- Carotenoids
- Flavonoids
- Volatile oil
- Steroidal saponins (capsicidins—in seeds only)

Key Actions

- Stimulant
- Tonic
- Carminative
- Relieves muscle spasms
- Antiseptic
- Increases sweating
- Increases blood flow to the skin
- Analgesic

Research

- **Capsaicin** Extensive clinical research shows that capsaicin, the compound in cayenne mostly responsible for its hot, pungent taste, has strong, local analgesic activity in certain types of nerve pain. Applied to the skin, capsaicin desensitizes nerve endings and acts as a counter-irritant. It is standardly prescribed for relief of neuralgic pain. It may also provide effective pain relief in conditions such as arthritis and headache.

Traditional & Current Uses

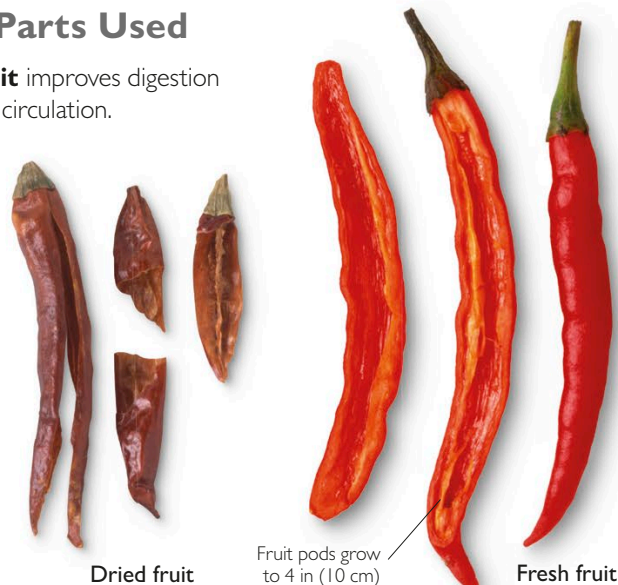
- **Warming stimulant** The herb's heating qualities make it a valuable remedy for poor circulation. It improves blood flow to the hands and feet and to the central organs.
- **Antimicrobial** In Mayan herbal medicine, cayenne was used to counter microbial infections—different *Capsicum* species including cayenne are now known to have significant antimicrobial activity. Adding cayenne to food reduces the chances of developing gastric or intestinal infection, and the herb is frequently used by herbalists to treat gastroenteritis and dysentery.
- **External uses** Applied locally to the skin, cayenne is mildly

**Cayenne**

A perennial, spiky shrub growing to 3 ft (1 m), with scarlet-red conical fruits filled with white seeds.

Parts Used

Fruit improves digestion and circulation.



Dried fruit

Fruit pods grow to 4 in (10 cm)

Fresh fruit

Key Preparations & Their Uses

- ⚠ **Cautions** Non-toxic at normal doses, although caution is required when eating or handling cayenne. Can cause intense pain and burning, and contact dermatitis.



Powder For sore throats, add a pinch to 5 tsp lemon juice. Dilute with hot water, add honey, and use as a gargle.



Infused oil Add 100 g chopped cayenne to 2 cups (500 ml) oil and simmer (see p. 294). Gently massage into rheumatic limbs.



Tincture (to make, p. 292). For arthritis, combine 20 drops with ½ cup (100 ml) willow bark tincture. Take 1 tsp with water twice a day.

- 🍬 **Tablets** are convenient for long-term use. Take for poor circulation.

- 👉 **Ointment** (to make, p. 295). Apply to chilblains (only if the skin is unbroken).

analgesic. It is also rubefacient, increasing blood flow to the affected part, and this helps to stimulate the circulation in “cold” rheumatic and arthritic conditions, aiding the removal of waste products and increasing the flow of nutrients to the tissues. Cayenne may also be applied to unbroken chilblains.

- **Internal uses** Cayenne is taken to relieve gas and colic and to

stimulate the secretion of digestive juices. It may be taken in frequent, small doses for a weak or failing heart. A pinch of cayenne is excellent when used in gargles for sore throats. Cayenne is also helpful in relieving acute diarrhea.

Self-help Uses

- **High fever**, p. 311.
- **Poor circulation**, p. 302.